

The bedroom which he slept in, she had always referred to as 'his room'. He had always slept there whenever he had visited her as far back as his high school days and later when he was in college and finally when he had been stationed in Texas in the Army. After a short time of conversation he indicated that he wanted to go to bed and they said their goodnights. He didn't sleep well at all. He lay awake, thinking about Kat at home and Elaine lying in the hospital.

In the morning, as soon as it was light outside, he got up and went to the kitchen where his aunt was making a pot of coffee. After a quick breakfast, he dressed and was soon backing his aunt's car out of the garage and into the street. He followed the directions she had given him during breakfast. "Down Greenville Avenue to Ross. Then take right turn at the Sears store. Keep on down Ross towards downtown 'till you come to Washington Avenue. Then turn left there and keep on 'till you come to Gaston. That's where the Baylor Hospital is. That's where your Momma died, ya know." Yes, he well remembered that.

Her directions had been good, and for that he was grateful. He had always had trouble finding his way around parts of Dallas and he was glad not to lose any time searching for his destination. As he approached Gaston Avenue, the group of buildings of Baylor Medical Center came into view. It had been eight years since he had been to Baylor at his mother's death, and it was very different now. The old original hospital building was now surrounded by a group of newer buildings. The park-like area which used to be in front of the hospital was now occupied by a new modern medical office building. He drove around the corner and saw a large parking garage. He drove into the entrance, stopped at the gate and punched the control box for a parking ticket. The bar lifted and he drove down into the garage and parked on the second level. An elevator brought him up to the street and as he stepped out into the cold morning air, he looked about, wondering where to begin his search for Elaine. He walked toward the closest building which was connected to its neighboring building by an overhead walkway which spanned the street between.

He entered the building at the street level lobby and spotted a sign that read "Patient Services". He walked up to the desk near the sign and said to the lady who was seated there, "I'm looking for a patient here and I have no idea where she might be located, Mam. She could be in any of these buildings I guess- I don't know which one though."

A SHORT STORY

"ELAINE" Page 7

"What is the patient's name, Sir? I can check in this building if you will give me the name."

"Elaine."

The woman looked at him with the forbearance shown by those who are used to dealing with stupidity. He then realized that he hadn't given her a last name.

"Grant. Elaine Grant..uh..Mrs. Elaine Grant."

The woman pushed some keys on the computer on her desk. Names began to roll on the monitor screen. More key pushing, and more data appearing on the screen. The lady frowned and said, "Sir, we show no patient under that name in the Johnson Building. Bob realized that the illness might offer a clue.

"She's a cancer patient." he said.

"Oh, I see." She dropped her gaze momentarily and then said, "Cancer patients are most likely to be in The Collins or Sammons Buildings."

"Where are they?"

"Take the elevator up to two in this building, then go through the crosswalk over the street to Collins. You'll be on the third floor when you come to the Collins Building, so don't let that confuse you. Take the elevator down to the first floor and the information desk will be able to help you find her. And Sir?"

"Yes?"

"Good luck."

He had found the room, after asking the nurse at the desk. It was back on the third floor. As he walked down the hallway looking for the number, he glanced at his wristwatch. It had been just over an hour since he left for the hospital. When he saw the number on the door, he checked the name in the holder. It read, "Mrs. Elaine Grant" with a doctor's name above it. The door was closed. He paused and listened, not wanting to go in if there were doctors or nurses in the room. No sound was discernable, so he pushed against the curved, hook-like handle which protruded from the door. The big, heavy door swung soundlessly into the room. The shades were drawn across the window, making it difficult to see well. The only light came from the bathroom door which was open just a crack. This let a narrow shaft of light spill out onto the dark tile floor, providing just enough illumination for him to distinguish the figure on the bed. There was no movement, or acknowledgement of his having entered. No sound came from the still figure which lay under the covers of the bed. One arm lay on top of the cover. There was an I.V. drip connected to a needle taped at the wrist. Her head was turned to the window, and Bob leaned over the bed, slowly, gently, to see her face. Her eyes were closed in sleep. The face which he looked at was gaunt and almost skull-like in

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appearance. The cancer had changed her features into the look of the women he remembered from the Nazi concentration camps during the war. He drew back from the bed, and quietly pulled a chair up to the side. As he set down in the chair, he reached out and took her hand into his. He felt a tiny responsive grip against his, but still no sound from her. Her head moved slightly but her eyes remained closed. Bob cried, silently and unashamedly and bent over to place his head on their clasped hands.

He thought about the last time he had seen her.

He had been in Dallas on business. His appointment had been with a client located on the LBJ Expressway and after leaving he decided to drive by the North Park Mall and take a chance on finding Elaine at the children's clothing store where she was the manager. He wasn't too surprised at her non-committal glance in his direction when he walked into the store. She hadn't seen him in about five years, and certainly wasn't expecting to see him now. She was placing tiny, folded shirts into glass shelving behind a counter and had resumed her work after glancing at him as he entered. She looked back up and a smile of recognition came onto her face. She put the clothes down on the counter and squealing with delight, she had walked up to him and put both arms around his neck and kissed him squarely on the mouth. "I'm shocked...I'm surprised, Bobby. What on earth brought this on?"

Bob was flushed from her enthusiastic greeting. He hadn't expected her to be that demonstrative in the store, especially with several clerks and customers looking on.

"I'm here for a meeting with a client, and I finished up early so I thought I'd come by and see how you are."

"Well, this is one big surprise, Bobby. I was beginning to think that you had stopped coming to Dallas after your mother died."

"That's about right, I don't get up here much anymore. When I do, I'm usually so rushed." He dared not to tell her that each time he came to Dallas, he would debate with himself as to whether or not he should call her, and he always decided against it. He knew if he did, he was chanceing the wrath of Kat.

Elaine said, "As you can see, I'm still a working girl.. by the way how did you know where to find me? I haven't seen you since I started working here."

"One of my spys from home told me about your job..so here I am." He had also heard she was having troubles with her husband but of course, could make no reference to that.

"Let's go get a cup of coffee," Elaine said. "We can exchange news and talk about home, and you can tell me all about how Kat is doing, and all about your wonderful family." He knew she didn't want to hear about Kat, but he did want to spend some time with her and talk.

"Let's go." Bob said.

She had given him the directions and they had driven to a French Bakery which served pastries and coffee. They had spent almost an hour in good conversation and friendly banter before he got up to pay their check. They walked out to the car and he held the door open for her. As she bent to the seat, she kissed him on the cheek, and said, "Still a perfect gentleman." After Bob had started the car and they were entering the traffic of the street, Elaine reached to Bob and placing her hand on his arm, said, "Bobby, I'm glad that you came by. I've got to tell you something. Something I've thought about a lot lately. My marriage has gone to hell. You may even have heard that we've been having trouble, I don't know. But Warren has become such a bastard. He's run through what money he inherited from his father's estate. He chases anything in a skirt, and now he's drinking too much. He takes off whenever he feels like it and stays gone for days at a time. He's gone right now, in fact. I'm at the point where I want a divorce, but so far haven't gotten the guts to go through with it. I know if I do, it will destroy him. His ego couldn't take my pulling out on him, even though he treats me like garbage, he still thinks I love him. I thought I did, up until a year or so ago. You just don't get over someone that easily, after you've been together as long as we have.

"Bobby, I've thought about you a lot lately. We had such good times when we were kids. I know we thought we were in love then...maybe what we felt for each other was love, but when I met Warren during the war I thought I was in love with him and you had gone into the service too...and...well you know what happened. All the thrill of an Air Force wedding just overwhelmed me and I made the mistake of my life. I'm admitting it to you, here and now."

Bob tried to interrupt her, but she placed her fingers across his mouth and said, "No, let me finish. I've started my confession and you are going to hear me out." Her eyes filled with tears as she continued.

"We've had to sell the house in University Park and by a small townhouse. We bought out closer to North Park so I wouldn't have so far to go to work. When I was packing for the move, I found our old high school yearbook and the ones from O.U. I sat down in the middle of the floor and went through all of the yearbooks and had myself a good cry. And you know that as I sat there in the middle of the floor of that house where I had spent a good many fairly happy years, I had to admit something to myself." She paused, waiting for his reaction.

"What did you have to admit?" he asked.

"That I had made the wrong choice a long time ago. And I also decided that if we ever saw one another again, I was going to tell you. I made the wrong choice, and screwed up my life. I chose the wrong guy, and I'm sorry Bobby...so very sorry. I'm glad that you've had a good marriage though. Kat has made a good wife for you, I know that, even though I say it begrudgingly, you've had a good marriage."

"Now, I want to show you something." They had reached the North West Parkway and she told him to turn east. They crossed the North Central Expressway and when they reached Skillman she told him to make a right turn. After several blocks, they came to a row of attractive, but small townhouses. Stop in front of the one on the end.

"Where are we?" Bob asked, although he felt he knew the answer.

"This is where I live, Bobby. You and I are going to go
to the end of the row of townhouses and turn down the
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"This is where I live, Bobby. You and I are going to go inside and I am going to go into my bedroom and turn down the sheets and I hope you will make love to me. It may not be as exciting as it would have been when we were young, but I guarantee that it will be done with deeper emotion and understanding than when we fumbled around on the golf course that night after the Senior Prom." She opened her side of the car and moved quickly up the walk toward the front entrance, her door key swinging in her hand.

* * * * *

Their love making had been slow, and tender. It was as if the pages of a long neglected and unread novel had been re-opened again. They explored each other's bodies with gentle hands and inquiring lips. They walked again on old, once familiar pathways, savoring every step of their journey, delaying as long as possible it's ending. The long, lost years of their lives were found again, and the two who had been separate were now joined once more.

"Any thoughts?" Elaine had asked, as they lay together, watching the pattern of light and shadow which flickered on the ceiling of the room.

"Yes. Many thoughts." Bob answered.

"Care to share, with an old friend?"

"First thought. I feel very happy. Second thought. You were right. It beats the hell out of the golf course."

"Will you tell Kat?"

He thought about her question for a few seconds, then answered. "I think not. She never has gotten over being jealous of you, you know. She'd kick my butt out if I told her something like that."

"What if she asks? Would you deny it?"

"No." He didn't need time to think about that question.

"I respect her too much to lie to her. I couldn't do that. I couldn't lie to her any more than I could lie to you. I didn't know anything like this was going to happen today. I can promise you, though, that if we let it happen again, eventually, Kat will know. She reads me like an open book. It would show every time we had been together."

Elaine pushed herself up on one arm and looking directly at Bob, asked the question which had been forming in her thoughts. "Does that mean that you aren't going to let it happen again?"

Bob reached out to her and stroked her cheek, then he slid his hand up into her hair. "That depends."

"On what?"

"On my will power, for one thing. On yours, for another."

Elaine set up on the side of the bed, looking out into the small landscaped courtyard outside her bedroom window. She stared at the shrubs and potted plants which she had worked so hard to get established when she had bought the townhouse. So familiar, they now somehow, looked different to her. She suspected that a good many things were going to look different to her now. She thought about her decision to bring Bobby to her bed...selfish of her she knew. She didn't give a damn about hurting Kat's feelings, but she was concerned about the problems that might be created for Bobby by what she had done.

"I'd better get back to the store." She told him this as she went into the bathroom.

They had both showered, dressed, and on the drive back to North Park Mall, little was said. Elaine put her hand on Bobby's knee as he drove. When he turned into the parking lot she told him, "Just drive to the mall entrance next to Neiman's. I'll get out there."

"Don't you want me to come in?" Bob asked.

"No. No need to."

He detected the annoyance in her reply. "Elaine, don't let what I said today spoil this for both of us. Don't be mad at me, please."

"I'm not mad at you Bobby. I'm mad at myself. I'll be as jealous of Kat now, as she has been of me. She has you and I don't." She leaned over and gave him a sisterly kiss on his cheek.

"Call me, if you're ever in the neighborhood." Then she got out of the car, shut the door behind her and was gone.